



Demystifying Behavioral Interviews

The Leadership Principles that matter most, role by role

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Engineering Leader, Amazon

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Meet the Hosts



Likhesh Bramhanwade

Engineering Leader, Amazon

- Leads software engineering teams delivering large-scale technology solutions
- Extensive experience hiring and evaluating talent
- Brings the interviewer's lens: leadership, problem-solving, collaboration, ownership and measurable impact



Ruchika Saluja

Senior Technical Product Manager

- Builds scalable platform and enterprise products
- Spans purchase journey, payments, invoicing, procurement integrations
- Combines customer insight, data and AI/ML to drive measurable business outcomes

Agenda

1

What interviewers are really looking for

Signals beyond technical skill

2

The Leadership Principles at a glance

Which ones get emphasized, and why

3

Role-by-role deep dive

Junior SDE, Senior SDE, SDM, TPM, Product Manager

4

Structuring your stories

STAR, the "I vs. we" rule, and quantifying impact

5

Building your story bank + Q&A

Prepare once, reuse across LPs

What Interviewers Are Really Looking For

Past behavior is the best predictor of future behavior



What YOU did

Your specific actions and decisions, not what "the team" did.



How you judged

Trade-offs, ambiguity, risks you weighed, and why you chose your path.



What changed

Measurable results: metrics, customer impact, and what you learned.

How the loop works: each interviewer is typically assigned a few Leadership Principles and probes 1–2 stories deeply with follow-ups. The bar rises with the level: same principle, bigger scope, harder trade-offs.

The Leadership Principles in Focus

The 13 principles emphasized across the roles in this session



LP Focus by Role

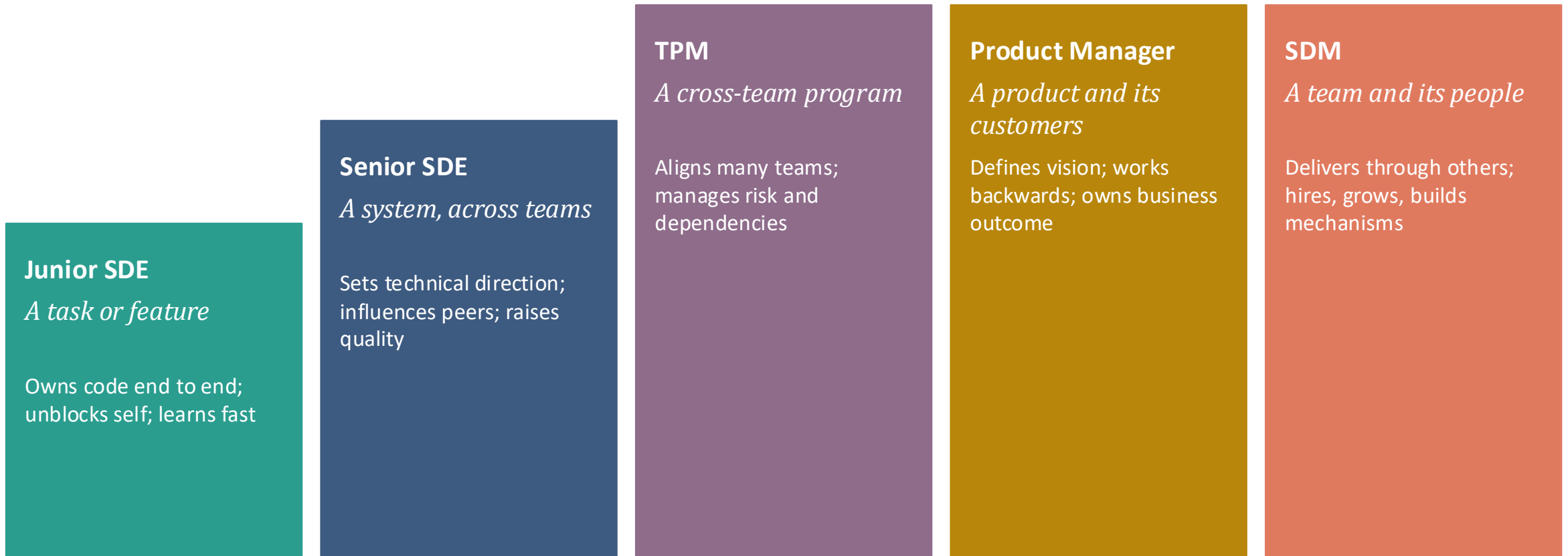
Which principles to prepare the deepest stories for

Leadership Principle	Junior SDE	Senior SDE	SDM	TPM	PM
Customer Obsession	●	●	●	●	●
Earn Trust		●	●	●	●
Deliver Results	●		●	●	
Think Big		●		●	●
Are Right, A Lot			●	●	●
Ownership	●	●			
Learn and Be Curious	●				●
Insist on the Highest Standards		●	●		
Bias for Action	●				
Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit		●			
Dive Deep		●			
Hire and Develop the Best			●		
Invent and Simplify					●

Same Principle, Different Bar

The scope of your stories should match the level you are interviewing for

Broader scope and influence →



ROLE 1 OF 5

Junior SDE

Scope: your tasks and features

The bar

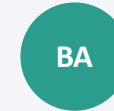
Show you own your work end to end, move fast with good judgment, and learn quickly.



Ownership

Took responsibility beyond the ticket: a flaky test, an on-call issue, a gap nobody owned.

"Tell me about a time you took on something outside your assigned work."



Bias for Action

Moved forward with a calculated risk instead of waiting; unblocked yourself.

"Tell me about a time you acted without having all the information."



Deliver Results

Met a commitment despite obstacles, and quantified what shipped.

"Describe a significant obstacle you hit while delivering a project."



Customer Obsession

Knew who uses your code and made a choice on their behalf.

"Tell me about a time you went out of your way for a customer."



Learn and Be Curious

Ramped up on unfamiliar tech and applied it to real work.

"Tell me about a time you had to learn something new quickly."

ROLE 2 OF 5

Senior SDE

Scope: systems that span teams

The bar
Show technical leadership: you raise the bar, influence without authority, and think long term.

ET

Earn Trust

Resolved conflict across teams; admitted mistakes; built credibility.

"Tell me about a time you gave difficult feedback to a peer."

OW

Ownership

Chose long-term health over short-term wins: tech debt, operability.

"Tell me about a time you traded short-term gains for long-term value."

HS

Insist on the Highest Standards

Raised the bar in design reviews, code quality or operational metrics.

"Tell me about a time you refused to compromise on quality."

BD

Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit

Challenged a decision with data, then committed fully once decided.

"Tell me about a time you strongly disagreed with your team or manager."

CO

Customer Obsession

Tied technical decisions to customer impact: latency, availability.

"Tell me about a time customer data changed a technical direction."

TB

Think Big

Proposed an architecture or vision beyond the immediate need.

"Tell me about a bold idea you drove that others doubted."

DD

Dive Deep

Went deep on metrics, logs and root cause; caught what others missed.

"Tell me about a time you dug into data to find a problem's root cause."

ROLE 3 OF 5

SDM

Scope: a team, its people and its outcomes

The bar

Show you deliver through others, grow people, and build mechanisms, not heroics.

ET

Earn Trust

Transparent with team and stakeholders; vocally self-critical.

“Tell me about a time you had to rebuild trust.”

DR

Deliver Results

Delivered through the team: re-scoped, re-staffed, made trade-offs.

“Tell me about a time your team was at risk of missing a key commitment.”

HD

Hire and Develop the Best

Raised the hiring bar, grew people, handled performance issues.

“Tell me about someone you developed, or an underperformer you managed.”

HS

Insist on the Highest Standards

Built mechanisms: COEs, operational reviews, quality gates.

“Tell me about a mechanism you created to raise the bar.”

RL

Are Right, A Lot

Sound calls on priorities and staffing; sought diverse views.

“Tell me about a decision you made with conflicting input.”

CO

Customer Obsession

Balanced customer needs against internal priorities on the roadmap.

“Tell me about a time you pushed back on a roadmap for the customer.”

ROLE 4 OF 5

TPM

Scope: programs across many teams

The bar

Show you align teams without authority, see the end state, and land complex programs.



Earn Trust

Aligned stakeholders with competing priorities; influenced without authority.

“Tell me about a time you aligned stakeholders who disagreed.”



Think Big

Defined a program vision and end state beyond the original ask.

“Tell me about a program you expanded beyond its original scope.”



Deliver Results

Drove dependencies and risks; recovered an off-track program.

“Tell me about a program that went off track and how you recovered it.”



Are Right, A Lot

Made sound scope and schedule calls with incomplete data.

“Tell me about a critical call you made with incomplete data.”



Customer Obsession

Kept the program anchored on customer outcomes, not internal convenience.

“Tell me about a time customer feedback changed program priorities.”

ROLE 5 OF 5

Product Manager

Scope: the product and the customer problem

The bar

Show you work backwards from customers, set bold vision, and make good product bets.

ET

Earn Trust

Credible with engineering, leaders and customers; says no well.

"Tell me about a time you said no to a key stakeholder."

TB

Think Big

Set a product vision (e.g. a PR/FAQ) with a meaningful bet.

"Tell me about the boldest product vision you have driven."

CO

Customer Obsession

Worked backwards from customer research and data.

"Tell me about a time customer insight changed your direction."

IS

Invent and Simplify

Found a novel solution or removed complexity for customers.

"Tell me about a time you simplified a complex product or process."

RL

Are Right, A Lot

Prioritization and bets validated by data; learned from misses.

"Tell me about a product decision that turned out wrong."

LC

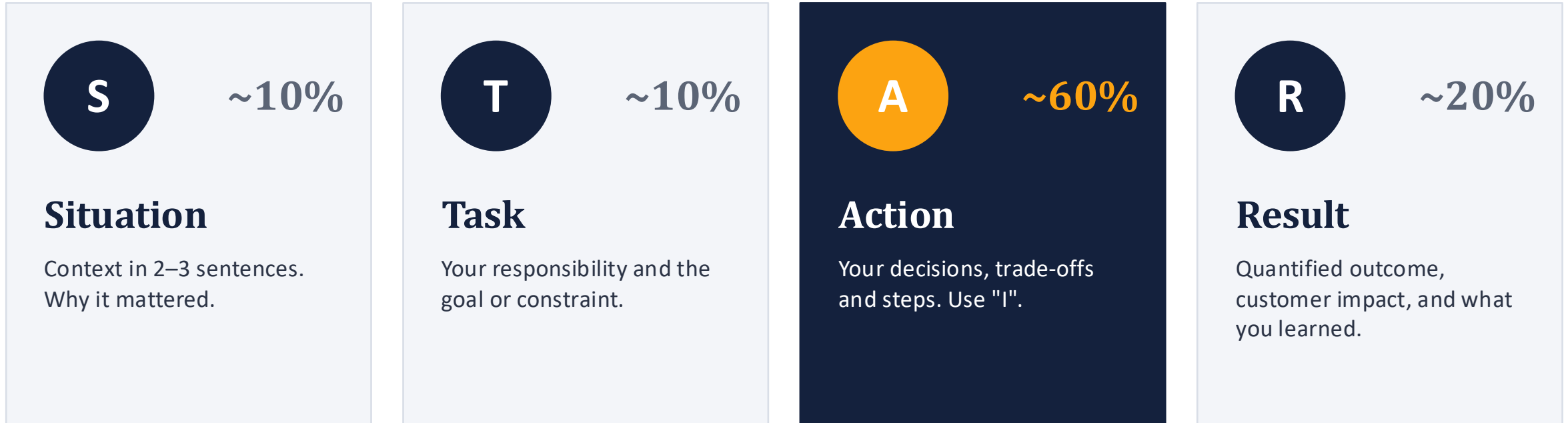
Learn and Be Curious

Learned a new domain or technology (e.g. AI/ML) to solve a problem.

"Tell me about a time you learned a new domain to serve customers."

Structure Every Story with STAR

Spend most of your time on what you did



Target length: 2–3 minutes for the first telling, then let the interviewer dive deep with follow-ups.

What Separates Strong Answers



Do

- Say "I" for your actions; credit the team for theirs
- Lead with numbers: latency, revenue, defects, time saved
- Name the trade-off and why you chose it
- Include a real conflict, risk or failure
- Close with the lesson and what you do differently now



Avoid

- Hide behind "we" so your role is unclear
- Stay hypothetical: "I would..." instead of "I did..."
- Spend 3 minutes on background, 30 seconds on action
- Pick a story where everything went smoothly
- Reuse one story for every principle

Build a Story Bank

Prepare 8–10 strong stories; each can serve 2–3 principles

- Mine your last 2–3 years: launches, incidents, conflicts, failures, people you grew.
- Write each in STAR with at least one metric.
- Tag a primary and secondary principle for each story.
- Cover every focus principle for your role at least twice.
- Keep at least one failure story you can tell comfortably.

Story	Primary	Also covers
Payments outage recovery	Ownership	Deliver Results, Dive Deep
Pushed back on launch date	Backbone	Highest Standards, Earn Trust
Migrated legacy invoicing	Think Big	Invent and Simplify
Grew a new hire to lead	Hire and Develop	Earn Trust
Wrong bet on a feature	Are Right, A Lot	Learn and Be Curious

Illustrative example: replace with your own stories

Expect the Dive Deep

Follow-ups test whether the story is really yours

1

What was your specific role?

Be precise about what you personally owned.

2

What data did you use?

Know the numbers before and after.

3

What alternatives did you consider?

Show the options you rejected, and why.

4

What would you do differently?

Honest reflection beats a perfect ending.

5

How did others react?

Show how you handled disagreement.

6

What happened next?

Long-term impact and follow-through.

Key Takeaways

- 1 Know the focus principles for your role and level
- 2 Match story scope to the level you want
- 3 Use STAR; spend ~60% on your actions
- 4 Quantify results and own the lessons
- 5 Prepare a story bank, not a script

Questions?



Thank You!

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